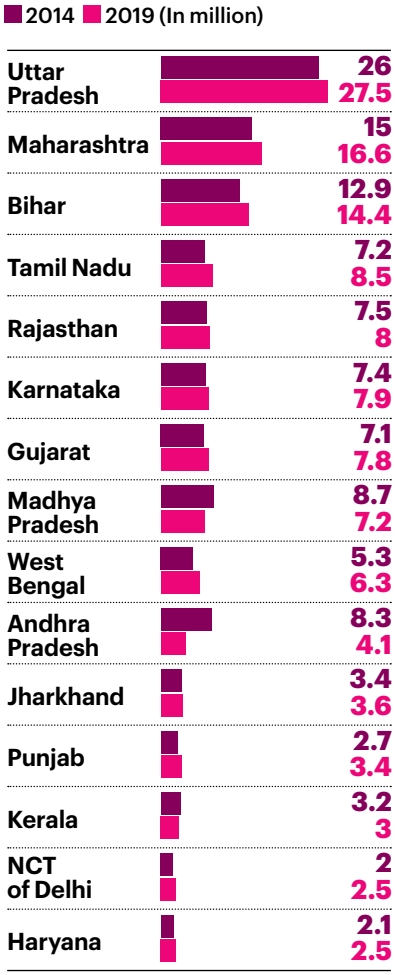
UP IN HIGHER NUMBERS TO CAST IT

Mixed Blessings

The gender gap remains huge in employment, literacy and internet access despite government efforts

UNTAPPED WOMEN VOTERS

130 million female electors in India still don't reach the booth to vote

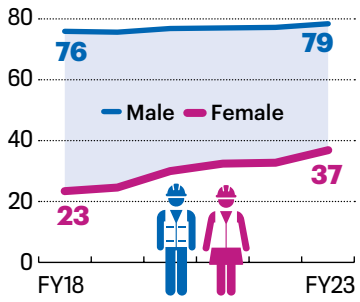


Source: SBI Research

FEMALE WORKFORCE

Women are still lagging behind men significantly in the country's workforce

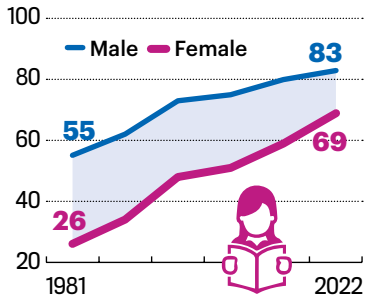
(Labour Force Participation Rate %, 15 years and above)



FEMALE LITERACY

Despite vast improvement in the past four decades, 3 in 10 women are still non-literate

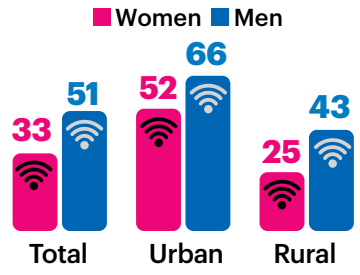
Literacy rate, adult (% of women and men aged 15 and above)



INTERNET USAGE

Given its limited usage among rural women, internet is yet to become their primary source of information

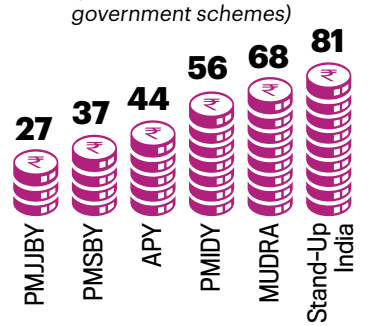
(% of women and men aged 15-49)



FINANCIAL EMPOWERMENT

Women have been substantial beneficiaries in these government welfare schemes

(% Share of women in government schemes)



Source: PLFS 2022-23, World Bank, SBI Research, NFHS-V

THAT PARTIES HAVE FOCUSED ON SCHEMES TO IMPROVE THE LOT OF WOMEN IS PROOF THAT THEIR VOTE IS MUCH SOUGHT-AFTER

In the ongoing general election, both the national parties—the BJP and the Congress—are waging a battle of guarantees to woo the woman vote. The Grand Old Party is conscious of the critical role its entitlement-led campaign played in helping it win Karnataka and Telangana last year. In its 2024 election manifesto, it has promised 'Nari Nyay', including a Rs 1 lakh annual cash transfer to the bank account of the eldest woman in every poor family and 50 per cent reservation in central government jobs. Not to be outdone, the BJP's 'Modi ki Guarantee' manifesto has a massive scheme to empower 30 million rural women by helping them become Lakhpati Didis.

Safety for women is another arena where political parties are wrestling to prove who protects women's interests better. So, if the BJP has latched on to Sandeshkhali to target Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee in West Bengal where it sees great scope for growth, the Con-